

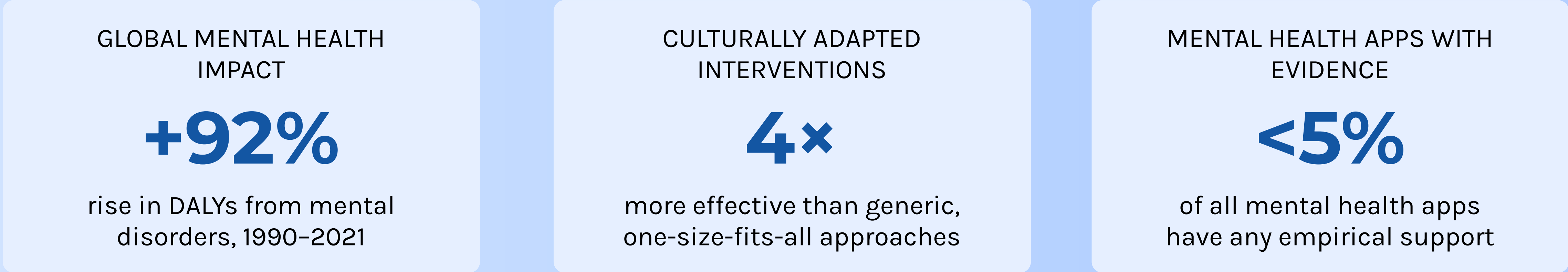
Mindfulness Across Cultures: Rethinking Mental Health Prevention

By Arcadia Calimano

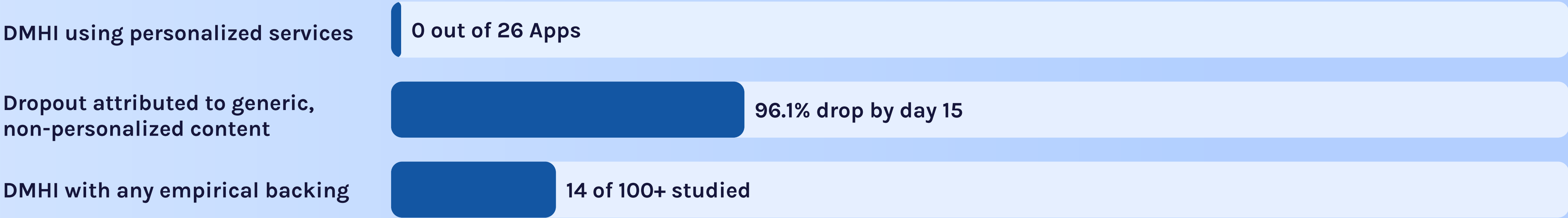


The Core Problem:

Adults without access to professional mental health care need culturally relevant coping strategies they can actually stick with, because generic tools don't work for everyone.



DALYs = disability-adjusted life years



GBD Study 2021, BMC Psychiatry (2025) · Griner & Smith, 2006 (76-study meta-analysis) · LeComte et al. via PMC, 2022 · JMIR scoping review, 2024 (n=525,824) · Fleming et al., 2018 · Synthesis of meta-analyses, 2025

**How might we help
people find and stick
with coping strategies
that actually fit who
they are?**



What I'm Building

A mental health app that actually knows you. Clinically proven coping strategies, personalized to your culture, your life, and your needs.



LONG-TERM VISION

Full app with habit-tracking, journaling, progress dashboards, and culturally-localized content libraries.



WHAT MAKES IT DIFFERENT

Every strategy recommended traces to peer-reviewed evidence, grounded in credible cross-cultural research and a long-term goal of retention.

01

DISCOVER

Strategies matched to cultural context, stressor type, and personal preferences.

02

PERSONALIZE

Adapt strategies based on individual responses and it's effectiveness over continuous use of the app.

03

TRACK

Measure wellbeing outcomes using habit tracking and daily mood logs to help keep you aware of whats working

Who Is This For?

This is for anyone caught between feeling okay and needing professional help, with no effective tools to get themselves there... **Adults Without Access to Proper Mental Health Care**

THE ACCESS GAP

42%

of Americans blame cost and insurance as a top barrier for mental health care.

1 in 4 are forced to choose between treatment and basic necessities.

THE SILENCE BARRIER

40%

of people across cultural backgrounds with anxiety and depression never seek help due to the mental health stigma.

31% hesitate specifically out of fear of being judged.

There are many who need support but cannot access traditional care, or have struggled to find a solution that fits their specific needs. My goal is to build a tool that removes that common struggle from the mental health journey.

Competitors

FINCH

Self-care pet app

STRENGTH

Strong emotional engagement through gamification. Habit formation and daily check-ins drive user retention.

LIMITATION

No peer-reviewed evidence base. Strategies are not clinically validated and have no cultural awareness built in.

HEADSPACE

Mindfulness app

STRENGTH

Backed by 50+ peer-reviewed studies. MBSR-aligned content with proven stress reduction outcomes.

LIMITATION

50% of RCTs had conflicts of interest involving Headspace funding. No personalization or stressor-matched content.

WOEBOT

AI CBT chatbot

STRENGTH

Clinically validated CBT delivery. Strong therapeutic alliance and user engagement in RCT settings.

LIMITATION

Original RCT was 79% Caucasian and US-only. Systematic reviews show lack of sample diversity as a consistent limitation.

What none of these apps do: Combine clinical evidence with cultural personalization: matching coping strategies to who the user is, where they come from, and what their research shows actually works for people like them.

What Makes this App Different?

Research-grounded, not trend-driven

Every recommended strategy traces back to healthy and peer-reviewed coping mechanisms such as problem-focused, emotion-focused, meaning-focused, and social coping. Everything is based in science rather than TikTok trends.

Culturally-aware by design

Most apps focus on the Western, individualistic user. This app explicitly accounts for how cultural context shapes what strategies feel accessible and effective informed directly by comparative research across a variety of different regions.

Effectiveness-oriented, not engagement-oriented

Most wellness apps optimize for daily active users. This one will orient around measurable outcomes ... did this strategy reduce your stress? Did your wellbeing improve? Grounded in validated instruments like ONS-4 and WEMWBS.

How I'm Building It

HTML

PAGE STRUCTURE

I will be using HTML to build the foundation of my pages:

- onboarding form
- results dashboard

CSS

VISUAL DESIGN

I will use CSS to create a calming, approachable experience with soft colors, warm typography, and a clean card-based layout

JS

INTERACTION

JS will create the full conversation behavior through displaying Onboarding questions, capturing user responses, storing conversation history, and sending it to the API.

AI API

AI ONBOARDING

the LLM will ask user a guided set of questions, interprets their responses, and give personalized, evidence-based coping strategy recommendations in real time.